SimplWorks.ai

SEO Playbook — Standard Website Optimization

Every client website gets this. No exceptions.
First deployed: Top Dog Vending (Feb 20, 2026)
Version 1.0

> **What this is:** A repeatable, four-tier SEO optimization process that gets applied to every website SimplWorks builds. It covers technical SEO, performance, content, and AI search readiness. Each tier builds on the last. Tier 1 is non-negotiable before launch. Tiers 2–4 are implemented based on client scope and budget.

Tier 1: Technical Foundations

REQUIRED — BEFORE LAUNCH

Do this before the domain goes live. Non-negotiable.

- ☐ **Page title & meta description**
  Title: 50–60 chars, include business name + location + primary keyword. Description: 150–160 chars, value prop + CTA.
- ☐ **Open Graph tags (og:title, og:description, og:image, og:url)**
  So links shared on social media show a rich preview. Use the best hero/product image as og:image (min 1200x630).
- ☐ **Twitter card (summary_large_image)**
  Same content as OG but in Twitter's format. Most platforms read both.
- ☐ **Canonical URL**
  Set to the production domain. Prevents Google from indexing preview/staging URLs.
- ☐ **Keywords meta tag**
  8–12 relevant keywords. Low direct SEO value but helps with organization and some search engines.
- ☐ **JSON-LD structured data — LocalBusiness**

For local businesses: name, address, phone, email, service area, business type, image, founders. Helps Google Knowledge Panel.

- [ ] **JSON-LD structured data — FAQPage**
  If the site has FAQ content, wrap it in FAQPage schema. Eligible for rich results in Google (expandable Q&A in search).

- [ ] **Sitemap.xml**
  Auto-generate via framework (Next.js: app/sitemap.js). List all public URLs with priority and changeFrequency.

- [ ] **Robots.txt**
  Auto-generate via framework (Next.js: app/robots.js). Allow all, point to sitemap URL.

- [ ] **Image optimization**
  Use next/image (or framework equivalent). Automatic WebP/AVIF, responsive srcset, lazy loading below fold, priority loading above fold. Descriptive alt text on EVERY image.

- [ ] **Semantic HTML**
  Proper heading hierarchy (one h1, h2s for sections, h3s for subsections). Use <main>, <section>, <article>, <footer> elements.

Next.js implementation:

- Metadata: `export const metadata = {...}` in layout.js (includes OG, Twitter, canonical, robots)
- `metadataBase: new URL('https://domain.com')` for canonical resolution
- Sitemap: `app/sitemap.js` exporting a function
- Robots: `app/robots.js` exporting a function
- Images: `import Image from 'next/image'` with width, height, sizes, alt props
- Structured data: `<script type="application/ld+json">` with `dangerouslySetInnerHTML`

Tier 2: Performance & Accessibility

HIGH IMPACT — FIRST WEEK

Run Lighthouse audit, fix issues, then deliver guides for non-code items.

- [ ] **Run Lighthouse audit (mobile + desktop)**
  `npx lighthouse URL --output=json --chrome-flags="--headless"` — target 90+ on all four categories.

- [ ] **Eliminate render-blocking resources**
  Switch Google Fonts to next/font. Inline critical CSS if needed. Defer non-essential JS.

- [ ] **Fix contrast issues (WCAG AA)**
  4.5:1 for normal text, 3:1 for large text. Use WebAIM contrast checker. Common fix: brighten muted text on dark backgrounds.

- [ ] **Add internal cross-links**
  Link sections to each other with descriptive anchor text within body copy. Subtle, natural — not "click here."

- [ ] **Google Business Profile guide (for local businesses)**
  Generate a PDF walkthrough the client can follow. Include: categories, description, photos to upload, review strategy.

- [ ] **Mobile verification**
  Lighthouse mobile audit confirms responsive behavior. CLS should be 0. LCP under 2.5s.

> **Target Lighthouse scores:** Performance 90+, Accessibility 95+, Best Practices 100, SEO 100. Anything below these warrants investigation and fixes before handoff.

Tier 3: Content Marketing

GROWTH — WEEKS 2–4

Each blog article is a new URL Google can index and rank. Minimum 3 articles at launch.

- [ ] **Build blog infrastructure**
  Blog index page, dynamic post routes, Article schema (JSON-LD) per post, responsive styling matching main site, CTA boxes on every post.
- [ ] **Write 3+ SEO-targeted articles**
  Pattern: 1 educational ("What is X?"), 1 comparison ("X vs. Y"), 1 trend/benefit piece ("Why [audience] is doing X"). Each 500–800 words with internal links back to main site.
- [ ] **Add blog to navigation, footer, and sitemap**
  Blog link in nav bar and footer. Sitemap auto-includes all blog URLs with proper lastModified dates.
- [ ] **Local citations guide (for local businesses)**
  Generate a PDF listing 8–10 directories to create listings on. Include copy-paste NAP info and business description. Key directories: Google, Yelp, Facebook, BBB, Apple Maps, Bing Places, Nextdoor, local Chamber of Commerce, LinkedIn.

Blog Article Template

Each article needs:

- SEO-optimized title (include primary keyword)
- Meta description (150–160 chars)
- Canonical URL
- Open Graph tags (type: article, publishedTime)
- Article JSON-LD schema (headline, description, datePublished, author, publisher)
- 2–4 internal links to main site sections
- CTA box at bottom driving to contact/conversion
- "Back to blog" navigation

Tier 4: AI Search Optimization (GEO)

ADVANCED — ONGOING

Optimize for ChatGPT, Perplexity, Google AI Overview. This is the future of search.

- [ ] **Rewrite FAQ answers for AI extraction**
  Every answer leads with a direct, quotable 1-sentence statement. Include entity names, location, and specific claims. AI pulls the first sentence as a snippet.

- [ ] **Add new FAQ items targeting AI queries**
  Think about what someone would ask an AI assistant: "What is [business]?", "How does [service] work?", "What does [service] cost?" Add those with clear, factual answers.
- [ ] **Add AI-pullable definition block**
  A concise, entity-rich summary paragraph on the page containing: business name, location, what they do, how it works, key differentiators. Visible text, not hidden. AI tools extract from visible content.
- [ ] **Service area pages (if applicable)**
  Individual pages for each city/area served. Each targets "[service] in [city]" queries.
- [ ] **Backlink strategy guidance**
  Advise client on: local press coverage, industry publications, partnerships, directory listings. Hard to manufacture but highest long-term value.

Quick Reference: Tools & Commands

TASK	TOOL / COMMAND
Lighthouse audit	`npx lighthouse URL --output=json --output-path=./report.json --chrome-flags="--headless"`
Lighthouse (mobile)	Default mode (no --preset flag)
Lighthouse (desktop)	Add `--preset=desktop`
Next.js font loading	`import { Font } from 'next/font/google'` with `variable` option
Image dimensions	`sips -g pixelWidth -g pixelHeight image.jpg` (macOS)
PDF generation	Chrome headless: `--headless --print-to-pdf=output.pdf --no-pdf-header-footer input.html`
Contrast checker	WebAIM: webaim.org/resources/contrastchecker
Schema validator	Google: search.google.com/test/rich-results
OG tag preview	opengraph.xyz or Facebook Sharing Debugger

Client Handoff Checklist

Before declaring a website "done," verify all of the following:

- [ ] Lighthouse desktop: 90+ Performance, 95+ Accessibility, 100 Best Practices, 100 SEO
- [ ] Lighthouse mobile: 90+ Performance, 100 SEO
- [ ] All images have descriptive alt text
- [ ] Sitemap.xml generates correctly with all public URLs
- [ ] Robots.txt allows crawling and points to sitemap
- [ ] OG image shows correctly when link is shared (test with opengraph.xyz)
- [ ] Structured data validates without errors (test with Google Rich Results Test)
- [ ] Canonical URL set to production domain
- [ ] No .env files or credentials exposed in the build
- [ ] Google Business Profile guide generated (for local businesses)
- [ ] Local citations guide generated (for local businesses)
- [ ] SEO optimization report generated for client file